Hemanth Vallamkonda

Five years in finance and operations; builds governed AI workflows • Right to work in the UK, no sponsorship

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FINANCE OPERATIONS LEAD (AI) · FOR A GLOBAL FINTECH, VIA CLIENT SERVER

AI spend, made accountable

The role's first month on a made-up FinTech on Azure: spend metered, reconciled to the invoice, owned, and a scale, fix or stop call per use case.

Usage is illustrative; prices are published list prices read on 3 November 2026 (sources).

October decision memo

ILLUSTRATIVE: A MADE-UP ORGANISATION

TO Finance director, use-case owners FROM Hemanth Vallamkonda (illustrative memo)

AI spend landed at $19,039, 110% of its $17,315 budget (115% of the August and September average). The ledger's forecast alert (not Azure's) went out on 8 October, twenty-two days before the actual-spend alert.

WHY IT MOVED

September to October, AI spend (+$3,955)

September	**$15,084**	
Volume	**+$1,767**	mostly KYC document review, runs up 38%
Unit price	**+$286**	`gpt-support-hard` moved from GPT-5.2 to GPT-5.4 on 8 October, at list price
Mix and consumption	**+$353**	largest in KYC document review: tokens and billed cost per run
Fixed shared platform	**+$193**	`srch-shared-uks`, a fixed daily charge shared by its users
Unattributed AI	**+$1,356**	`gpt54-sandbox`, billed AI with no use case and no gateway calls
October	**$19,039**	

CONTROL CHECKS

> **88% of spend has a named owner** (Walk; target 85%); `rg-shared-observability` has none.

> **Gateway metering explains 85% of token-billed AI cost;** `gpt54-sandbox` is billed with no gateway calls.

DECISIONS

▲ SCALE

Support assistant

$0.025 avoidable per accepted draft
value $2.40
84% succeed (bar 80%)

Value is 96× avoidable cost; bar met. Levers below take it to $0.020.

▲ SCALE

Fraud alert explanations

$0.0048 avoidable per explanation used
value $0.60
46% succeed (bar 40%)

Value is 126× avoidable cost; bar met. Levers below take it to $0.0038.

FIX

KYC document review

$0.20 avoidable per approved summary
value $12.00
66% succeed (bar 85%)

34% of cost went on failed or rejected runs. Next: pre-check documents and cap retries on long PDFs.

FIX

Internal knowledge assistant

$0.076 avoidable per useful answer
value $0.55
$0.58 with the shared tier
39% succeed (bar 60%)

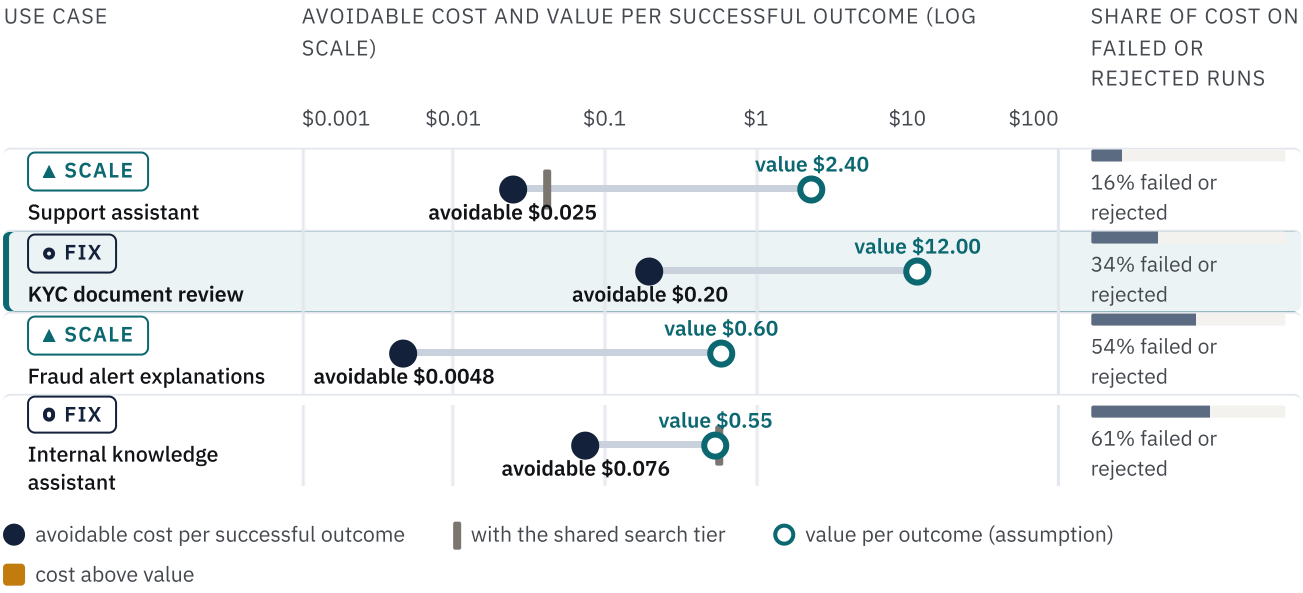
61% of cost went on failed or rejected runs. Stopping would shift its search-tier share to the support assistant ($0.042 to $0.068 per accepted draft). Fix retrieval; right-size the tier.

Unit economics

Avoidable cost and illustrative value per successful outcome; share lost to failed or rejected runs.

ILLUSTRATIVE

ILLUSTRATIVE Avoidable cost per successful outcome against its value, October. Log scale: each gridline is ten times the last. Decisions are for October.



KYC document review, October: P50 $0.19 and P90 $0.20 of daily avoidable cost per approved summary; 34% of cost on failed or rejected runs; cache hit rate 10%; 84k tokens per approved summary.

Unit economics, October. Illustrative: a made-up organisation. Avoidable cost is what stops if the use case stops (model tokens and embeddings); every run counts, including failed, retried and discarded ones. The daily range is of avoidable cost.

USE CASE	ALLOCATED AI SPEND	SUCCESSFUL OUTCOMES	AVOIDABLE COST PER OUTCOME	WITH SHARED TIER	VALUE PER OUTCOME	FAILED OR REJECTED
Support assistant Customer Operations	$5,772	137,974 accepted drafts	**$0.025**	$0.042	$2.40	16%
KYC document review Financial Crime	$5,984	29,501 approved summaries	**$0.20**	same	$12.00	34%
Fraud alert explanations Fraud Analytics	$1,627	341,395 explanations used	**$0.0048**	same	$0.60	54%
Internal knowledge assistant Engineering	$4,207	7,305 useful answers	**$0.076**	$0.58	$0.55	61%
Use-case AI spend	**$17,591**	includes $5,982 of fixed shared platform (the AI Search tier, split by retrieval calls); unattributed AI (no use case) $1,447; all AI spend $19,039				

Value assumptions are in value.json, for owners to replace.

Savings pipeline

Every saving shows its method and evidence grade; levers apply in sequence and are checked on the next bill by unit cost. ILLUSTRATIVE

MEASURED
$3,552 a month

WITH ASSUMPTION-BASED
$4,740 a month

WITH FOUNDATION PRIORS
$5,314 a month

REALISED IN OCTOBER
$2,177 in the month

Monthly savings by lever, priced from the October ledger. Illustrative.

LEVER	SAVING A MONTH	EVIDENCE	METHOD AND QUALITY GATE	NEXT-BILL CHECK	STATUS

LEVER	SAVING A MONTH	EVIDENCE	METHOD AND QUALITY GATE	NEXT-BILL CHECK	STATUS
▲ SCALE **Support assistant**					
Route simple hard-case tickets from GPT-5.4 to GPT-5.4 mini Owner: Customer Operations	$380	☐ Foundation prior	Foundation prior: 40% of the path eligible (assumption); 60% to 90% range, counted at 60%. Gate: Acceptance on routed tickets within 2 points of GPT-5.4 in a 200-ticket shadow test Routing starts a new prompt cache on the mini deployment, so the caching lever is priced after it.	avoidable cost per accepted draft: $0.025 now, $0.022 or less next bill	identified
Put the stable 4,000-token prefix first so automatic caching hits Owner: Customer Operations	$152	◧ assumption-based	Assumption-based: hit rate 17.4% measured; the stable 4,000-token prefix is 24.2% of the average 16,508-token prompt, so at most 24.2% of input can hit. Cached input at 10% of the input price then saves 7.2% of input cost. Gate: No change to draft content: the prompt is reordered, not rewritten	avoidable cost per accepted draft: $0.025 now, $0.021 or less next bill	identified
Cap reply length and ask for structured drafts Owner: Customer Operations	$96	☐ Foundation prior	Foundation prior: 10% to 40% range, counted at 10%. Gate: Agent acceptance rate does not fall	avoidable cost per accepted draft: $0.025 now, $0.020 or less next bill	identified

LEVER	SAVING A MONTH	EVIDENCE	METHOD AND QUALITY GATE	NEXT-BILL CHECK	STATUS

Try the support assistant's levers: what one accepted draft really costs

ILLUSTRATIVE Defaults are the support assistant as measured in October; prices are Azure list prices read on 3 November 2026 S11.

Model cost per accepted draft	**$0.024**
Review time per accepted draft	**$1.05**
Total per accepted draft	**$1.07**
Model bill a month at 138,000 drafts	**$3,323**
With review time	**$147,894**



model review time

Review time is 98% of the cost of an accepted draft: a minute saved in review is worth more than any model lever.

At the October defaults the model cost is $0.024 per accepted draft at list price. The ledger's billed model-token cost is $0.025 (hard cases use longer prompts, and the bill carries the negotiated discount), and $0.042 once embeddings and the shared search tier are added.

FIX KYC document review

LEVER	SAVING A MONTH	EVIDENCE	METHOD AND QUALITY GATE	NEXT-BILL CHECK	STATUS
Batch the overnight KYC document runs Owner: Financial Crime	not counted	not graded	Blocked: Anthropic's batch platforms list does not include Microsoft Foundry. • Run the overnight backlog through a platform that lists batch for Claude (the Claude API), after a procurement and data-residency review • Stay on Foundry and cache the shared review instructions instead Gate: Not applicable until a platform route is agreed	none until priced	blocked
Pre-check documents and cap retries on long PDFs Owner: Financial Crime	$241	assumption-based	Assumption-based: failure rate 16.1% against 11% in the two prior months (measured); a page-count pre-check and a two-retry cap remove 80% of the excess failures (assumption). Gate: Approval rate on documents that pass the pre-check does not fall	avoidable cost per approved summary: $0.20 now, $0.19 or less next bill	identified

LEVER	SAVING A MONTH	EVIDENCE	METHOD AND QUALITY GATE	NEXT-BILL CHECK	STATUS
▲ SCALE **Fraud alert explanations**					
Send the overnight explanation backlog through the Batch API Owner: Fraud Analytics	$325	assumption-based	Assumption-based: 40% of explanations are for the overnight re-scoring backlog and can wait up to 24 hours (assumption from the team's process; confirm from gateway timestamps); Batch is 50% off input and output on Azure Global Standard. Gate: Backlog explanations ready before the morning review	avoidable cost per explanation used: $0.0048 now, $0.0038 or less next bill	identified
○ FIX **Internal knowledge assistant**					
Trim retrieved context to the top passages Owner: Engineering	$98	Foundation prior	Foundation prior: 20% to 60% range, counted at 20%. Gate: Share of answers rated useful does not fall	avoidable cost per useful answer: $0.076 now, $0.063 or less next bill	identified
Shared AI platform					
Right-size the shared AI Search tier Owner: Engineering	not priced	not graded	Not priced: no AI Search price in this pack's research: measure query load and index size, then price the smaller tier from the Azure Retail Prices API. Gate: Retrieval latency and answer quality hold for both users of the index	none until priced	identified
Cloud estate					
Rightsize VMs that stayed under the CPU threshold all quarter Owner: Fraud Analytics, Financial Crime	$469	assumption-based	Assumption-based: 2 VMs (vm-fraud-scoring-01, vm-kyc-ocr-01) under 20% P95 CPU all month; one size down in the same series (D16s v5 to D8s v5, D8s v5 to D4s v5) halves the hourly rate in this illustrative rate card; confirm both rates from the Azure Retail Prices API before counting it. Gate: P95 CPU on the new size stays under the owner's limit for two weeks	cost per VM-day: $15.12 now, $7.56 or less next bill	identified
Scale non-production AKS to zero at night and at weekends Owner: Engineering	$3,552	measured	Measured from the bill: mean daily cost $202 in September, $87 from the change; 64% of hours are scheduled off. Gate: Test environments up by 07:00 on working days	non-production cluster cost per day: $202 now, $87.01 or less next bill	realised

LEVER	SAVING A MONTH	EVIDENCE	METHOD AND QUALITY GATE	NEXT-BILL CHECK	STATUS
Lifecycle tiering for logs and cost exports Owner: Engineering	not priced	not graded	Not priced: no storage price in this pack's research: to be priced from the Azure Retail Prices API. Gate: Audit retention periods still met	none until priced	identified
Savings plan for the steady compute floor Owner: Engineering	not priced	measured floor	92 days of baseline, past the 60 to 90 days the Foundation asks for before committing. Production compute never fell below $711 a day at pay-as-you-go rates ($29.61 an hour) after the rightsizing above, so commit to that floor, not the mean. A savings plan commits a discounted hourly amount: $29.61 × (1 − d), where d is the discount Microsoft's savings plan recommendation gives for this SKU mix. d is not in this pack's sources, so the commitment stays a formula, not a number. Gate: rightsizing done first, then size to the new floor	effective cost per compute hour falls	recommended
Provisioned throughput (PTU) for AI Owner: Engineering	not priced	not graded	Not yet. Daily production tokens swing 2.3× between the quietest and busiest day and AI volume is still moving; PTU sizing needs the Foundry capacity calculator, so it is not priced. Gate: a stable 60 to 90 day token baseline	none	not yet

Background that fits

Reporting packs.
At Kuruvella & Co., ~35% less report preparation time across 30+ SME client entities.

Measuring a unit of work.
At Bnk To The Future, ~25% faster turnaround across 100+ cases, with management and risk-committee reporting.

Governed review steps.
At MTest Labs, test design went from an 8-hour day, or 2 to 3 days, to 1 to 3 supervised hours; a tester approves every case.

Contact

How it works has the code; the pack runs with `node --test`.

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Prepared by Hemanth Vallamkonda as part of an application to a global FinTech via Client Server. Independent and illustrative; uses public information only.

The organisation, its usage and its bill are made up. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Client Server or its client. Prices: Anthropic and Azure Retail Prices list prices, read 3 November 2026.

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